Urgency, or the Appearance of Urgency? A Corpus-Assisted Critical Discourse Analysis of Institutional Legitimation in UN SDG 13 Discourse

Introduction

The discourse of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) has been a topic of scholarly interest. As the framework is often described as a list of goals to achieve a better and more sustainable future for all by 2030, it often invites many researchers to examine the discourse surrounding it. Climate action is one of the concerns addressed by the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), with SDG 13 explicitly calling for urgent action to combat climate change and its impacts (United Nations, 2015). As this goal connects environmental protection with institutional commitments, the language used to communicate it becomes a relevant object of study. Most importantly, urgency can be examined through the ways climate problems are presented and particular responses are justified. To illustrate this, suppose a report calls for immediate action. It may also indicate who is expected to respond and which responses are presented as necessary. This exact relationship makes SDG 13 a particularly relevant setting for examining institutional legitimation through climate action discourse.

In doing this, the annual SDG reports seem to provide a suitable setting for this examination. The SDG 13 sections of these reports go beyond describing climate conditions. They can also be read for how they assign responsibility and position institutions within climate governance. At the same time, examining how immediate demands are connected with future targets or consequences may help clarify how urgency is constructed within these representations. Due to that, this topic is chosen to highlight the relationship between urgent language and institutional authority. Evidently, recognizing urgency in a report does not establish that the institutions represented have acted with corresponding urgency. This study, therefore, will examine how the SDG 13 sections of annual UN SDG reports construct climate action as urgent and legitimize particular actors or responses. A corpus-assisted critical discourse perspective will support this examination of recurring language patterns and their implications for institutional authority.

Previous Research

SDG discourse shown in reports, press releases, and other institutional texts does not simply report the reality of the environment. It constructs specific meanings of sustainability, responsibility, and governance. To illustrate, Sénit (2020) goes in depth regarding the constraints of the SDGs, with 70% of 122 sampled texts concerning environmental goals expressing a progressive sustainability discourse. This discourse accepts a growth-based

development model yet calls for state-centric reforms to promote equity between developed and developing nations. Beyond analyses of individual SDG documents, Wang and Huan (2024) highlight the relevance of critical discourse studies for understanding public communication about climate change. More recently, Wagener (2026) analyzes official texts covering all 17 SDGs. His findings suggest that the global SDG text corpus revolves discursively around national economic developmental strategies, while topics regarding environmental sustainability and human vulnerability appear to be left to disconnected narrative clusters. Interestingly, the same research associates SDG 13 with a distinct narrative class concerning institutional action, which suggests an emphasis on institutional management in the framing of climate governance.

To show how these institutions justify why certain actors have authority, responsibility, and legitimacy to act, previous studies have used a range of approaches. Hansson and Page (2022) analyzed a corpus of tweets amounting to 42,618 words by the UK Brexit Department, showing that government communication employs rationalization and moral evaluation strategies that defend policy choices by linking them to positive future outcomes. At the domestic level, Hustad (2023) suggests that the SDGs do not function merely as universal mandates. They are actively reconstructed and legitimized by domestic stakeholders to align with their interests and goals. Similarly, Fuoli and Beelitz (2024) suggest that corporations heavily cite external global frameworks such as the SDGs and the Paris Agreement to show an alignment with international sustainability norms. At the same time, fossil fuel producers seem to promote optimistic technological solutions (carbon capture and offsets) and frame future energy demand growth as inevitable. Besides corporations, many foundations also employ legitimation strategies. Dehlsen et al. (2025) use discursive legitimation approaches and find that philanthropic foundations employ libertarian and utilitarian frameworks when moving from abstract values to project implementation. This happens through rationalization and mythopoesis, in which legitimation happens through market mechanisms and data-driven altruism, while mythopoesis is employed to morally justify the extreme wealth accumulated by the founders.

Finding these discursive patterns requires methodological approaches that can reveal both recurring linguistic patterns and their broader social meanings. With that in mind, corpus-assisted discourse studies (CADS) have become increasingly employed by researchers to combine the quantitative analysis of textual patterns with the rich qualitative interpretations of discourse functions. To illustrate its use, researchers such as Cunningham et al. (2022)

integrate lexical tools such as Sketch Engine to run keyword extraction and concordance analysis of the phrase “climate change” in two specialized spoken sub-corpora totaling 56,854 words, in which semantic fields such as negative environmental impacts, industry, finance, and legislative politics can be determined. This approach exposes contrasting ideological positions that would otherwise have been hidden in close reading. Similarly, Liu and Huang (2022) employ advanced corpus-linguistic tools across a 20-year longitudinal corpus from *The New York Times* to track micro-linguistic choices, term-level framing shifts, and stance-taking. In addition to that, Cui (2024) shows that combining corpus software (AntConc) and topic modeling with Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) can allow the researcher to notice comparisons between institutional and private corporate releases. This combination is further illustrated by Fuoli and Beelitz (2024), who analyzed 529 sustainability disclosures from 69 companies, amounting to a corpus size of approximately 15.7 million words. This corpus was analyzed through Sketch Engine for keyword extraction, dispersion filtering, concordance sampling, and collocation analysis, illustrating how macro-level statistical scanning can be paired with micro-level concordance analysis to explore the gap between institutional pledges and concrete action.

With these in mind, the discourse surrounding the SDGs may seem to have been deeply examined through various theoretical and methodological perspectives. However, the studies reviewed here have mainly focused on specific aspects of SDG and climate discourse rather than exploring the intersection between institutional legitimation, urgency construction, and corpus-assisted analysis within UN SDG 13 discourse. For one, Sénit (2020) and Wagener (2026) have mainly explored broader issues of sustainability, governance, and ideological tensions within global developmental frameworks, leaving limited attention to the specificity of how legitimation strategies work within climate action discourse. Secondly, Hansson and Page (2022), Fuoli and Beelitz (2024), and Dehlsen et al. (2025) examine legitimation in governmental, corporate, and philanthropic contexts, rather than international institutions such as the United Nations. Finally, while Cunningham et al. (2022) and Liu and Huang (2022) illustrate the value of corpus-assisted approaches in identifying linguistic patterns within climate discourse, these examples do not directly address the joint construction of institutional authority and urgency in the SDG 13 sections of annual UN reports. This study, therefore, seeks to address these gaps by applying a corpus-assisted Critical Discourse Analysis approach to UN SDG 13 discourse. By integrating corpus-based analysis with van Leeuwen’s (2007) legitimation framework and Vaara et al.’s (2024)

integrative framework, this study examines how urgency and institutional legitimacy are constructed through language in the SDG 13 sections of annual UN SDG reports.

Theoretical Framework

To examine how institutional authority and climate action are justified through language, this study draws on van Leeuwen's (2007) legitimation framework. This framework identifies four principal strategies of legitimation, namely authorization, moral evaluation, rationalization, and mythopoesis. Authorization refers to appeals to established authority, including laws, traditions, institutional positions, and expertise. As an example, a statement that government should reduce emissions in accordance with the recommendations of climate scientists could justify action through expert authority. The recommendations would support the demand for action because of the credibility attributed to those providing them. Moral evaluation draws on values that present a practice as desirable or appropriate. An example of this can be seen in the event that describes climate action as an ethical duty to protect vulnerable communities. In this particular example, action would be justified through a value of responsibility toward those exposed to harm. These two categories, authorization and moral evaluation, help distinguish appeals to authority from appeals to values, while also allowing the study to consider how both may occur within the same page.

To continue, rationalization justifies practices through their purposes, expected usefulness, or established knowledge. For example, an argument that expanding early warning systems would reduce disaster losses could present investment as legitimate because of its expected benefits. The justification would depend on the connection drawn between the proposed measure and desirable outcome. Lastly, mythopoesis works through narratives in which legitimate actions are rewarded, and illegitimate actions are associated with negative outcomes. To illustrate, a hypothetical situation could describe a coastal community that invested in flood preparedness, evacuated its residents when a storm arrived, and subsequently avoided loss of life. This sequence would present preparedness as a legitimate course of action through the positive outcome attributed to it. Hence, the justification would emerge through the story of what happened to the community. Ultimately, by applying van Leeuwen's categories to UN climate action discourse, this study seeks to identify how particular responses are justified and how these justifications contribute to the presentation of institutional authority and urgency.

While van Leeuwen's framework identifies the strategies through which practices are legitimized, Vaara et al. (2024) provide a broader account of the conditions in which discursive legitimation occurs. Their integrative framework encompasses five elements, namely strategies, positions, foundations, temporality, and arenas. Strategies concern how legitimacy is constructed. An example of this is a passage that combines an appeal to scientific recommendations with an argument that adaptation investment would prevent future losses. Examining this combination would show how different means of justification work together within a passage. On the other hand, positions concern the roles and identities through which actors are given authority, credibility, or a voice in legitimation. A hypothetical passage presenting governments as responsible decision makers and the UN as a coordinator could illustrate how institutional roles are constructed. The analysis would consider how these representations support the authority attributed to each actor. Foundations, meanwhile, refer to the underlying discourses and assumptions on which legitimating arguments rest. For example, a hypothetical argument that international coordination is the appropriate response to climate risks could rely on the assumption that such risks exceed the capacity of any single state. This premise would help make coordination appear necessary and support the role of a coordinating institution. With these in mind, the framework allows the study to connect particular strategies with the institutional roles and assumptions that give them meaning.

A point of particular importance is temporality, which concerns how legitimation unfolds over time and how the past, present, and future are represented. In this study, attention will be given to how temporal representations contribute to urgency. To illustrate, a hypothetical statement that governments must act now to achieve a climate target by 2030 could connect an immediate demand with a future deadline. The analysis would examine how this connection presents action as time-sensitive and makes delay appear difficult to justify. Arenas, in turn, concern the discursive settings in which legitimation takes place and is shaped. For example, a hypothetical adaptation commitment presented in an annual UN SDG report could be framed through formal progress assessments and appeals to shared international goals. Examining this setting would help explain how the reporting context shapes the presentation of that commitment. At the same time, the reports provide a particular setting for institutional representations, rather than evidence of how every audience receives them. Discursive attempts to establish legitimacy do not automatically demonstrate their acceptance. By bringing the two frameworks together, this study can examine how climate

action is justified through language while considering how institutional roles, underlying assumptions, and temporal representations shape those justifications within the reports.

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Generative AI Transparency Statement

Student Name : Fauzi Fadhlurrohman
Student ID : 2406406080
Course : Penulisan Ilmiah
Assignment : Midterm
Date : 15th October 2026

1. AI Use Declaration

Please select one:

☐ I did not use generative AI tools in completing this assignment.
✔ I used generative AI tools in completing this assignment, as disclosed below.

2. AI Tools Used

If you used generative AI, list the tool(s) and the LLM model as specifically as possible (Example: GPT-5.4 Pro, Gemini 2.5 Flash, Claude Haiku 4.5, DeepSeek-R1, etc.):
Tool(s): GPT-6.1 Sol, Gemini 3.8 Flash

3. How I Used AI

Check *all* that apply:

✔ Brainstorming or generating initial ideas
✔ Developing an outline or organizing ideas
✔ Clarifying concepts or course materials
✔ Finding possible keywords or directions for research
☐ Language/grammar correction
☐ Improving clarity or style of my own writing
☐ Translation
✔ Summarizing materials
☐ Generating or revising text
☐ Generating images, audio, video, or other media
☐ Coding/data analysis
☐ Other: _____

4. Description of AI Assistance

Explain what you asked each AI tool to do and how you used its output in the final assignment. Be specific and include all the steps (research, drafting, editing, etc.)

My use of AI primarily revolves around ideation and article searching. The research problem and theory came from me, as it is a topic I've always been interested in, and AI was an assistant in discussing my initial ideas, clarifying concepts, and identifying potentially relevant articles.

During research, ChatGPT assisted me by suggesting relevant literature and helped explain the arguments, methods, and theoretical concepts discussed in said articles, although most of the ideation still came from me.

For drafting, I developed the structure, put together the discussion, and wrote the assignment myself. After drafting, I asked GPT to review the text for grammar mistakes and citation order.

5. Extent of AI Contribution

Which statement best describes the role of AI in your assignment?

☐ *Minimal*: AI was used only for minor assistance, such as grammar or proofreading.

✔ *Limited*: AI assisted with specific parts of the process, but the ideas, analysis, and the majority of the work are my own.

☐ *Substantial*: AI contributed significantly to the development, wording, structure, analysis, or production of the assignment.

6. Security

Briefly explain how you protected confidential, personal, or sensitive information when interacting with the tool.

I avoided sharing personal or sensitive information and limited what I say to academic content relevant to the assignment.

7. Student Declaration

I confirm that this statement accurately and completely describes my use of generative AI in completing this assignment, according to Rector's Decree No. 16 [2026] on Generative AI in academic writing. I understand that disclosing AI use does not automatically make such use permissible and that all AI use must comply with the requirements of this course and assignment.

I remain solely responsible for the accuracy, originality, citations, arguments, and all other content submitted under my name. I am also responsible for ensuring that any materials entered into third-party AI systems can be legally and ethically shared with those systems. Personal data, confidential information, identifiable research-participant data, and other protected materials must not be uploaded unless explicitly authorized.

I understand that violations of academic integrity, research ethics, data privacy, or other applicable ethical requirements may result in disciplinary action in accordance with Universitas Indonesia's academic integrity policies (Rector's Decree No. 4 [2024]).

Depok, 15th October 2026



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